should be in office when Chinese President Xi Jinping was scheduled to visit Nepal in October.

Oli survived as prime minister until 4 August 2015. Xi's trip was not cancelled, as some Indian newspapers predicted at the time, but postponed because of the political crisis in Nepal. In October Xi attended a BRICS-BIMSTEC (Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa and the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation) meeting in Goa, India, where he shook hands with Oli's successor Prachanda and pledged that he would visit Nepal 'at an earliest convenient date'.[59]

Even the Madhesis, who were thought to be close to India, turned to the Chinese for help. On 18 March 2016, a delegation from the Samyukta Loktantrik Medhesi Morcha went to the Chinese embassy in Kathmandu to hand over a memorandum expressing their opposition to the new constitution and seeking Chinese support to help put pressure on the then Oli government to address their grievances. A Madhesi-dominated political party, the Federal Socialist Forum, Nepal, and a faction of the Madhesi Jana Adhikar Forum, have also received support from the Chinese embassy for their activities, underscoring the fact that the Chinese always hedge their bets and never put all their eggs in one basket.

Politics in Nepal remains as messy as ever and became messier still when Bhattarai split with Prachanda and launched a new political party called Naya Shakti (New Force) in July 2016. It had been known for some time that differences existed between the two Maoist leaders, with the more intellectual Bhattarai feeling uncomfortable with Prachanda's consolidation of power in his own hands. But the actual policies of Bhattarai's new party are not quite clear other than that it intends to have a directly elected presidential system to solve the problem of constant crises and political chaos. Bhattarai also opposes the new constitution and has expressed support for the Madhesis, a position welcomed by India.

Even if India remains Nepal's main foreign trade partner and continues to give substantial foreign aid to the country, there is no doubt that China has developed a very special relationship with successive Nepalese governments as well as civil society in all spheres, politically as well as economically. China is also moving closer to Nepal in other respects. In 2005, China finished building a railway from Xining, the capital of Qinghai province, to Lhasa. Xining was already in 1959 connected with China's